

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Lead: ♣J

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥

Declarer: East

Lead: ♣Q

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♠5

Board: 4

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥

Declarer: West

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♦Q

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 5
♥ 3
♦ K 10 9 2
♣ 7 6 5 4 2

♠ A K Q J

♥ 7 4 2

♦ J 8 6 4

♣ K Q



♠ 9 6 3
♥ A 10 9 8
♦ A Q 5
♣ J 10 9

♠ 7 4 2

♥ K Q J 6 5

♦ 7 3

♣ A 8 3

West	North	East	South
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	2♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North

Lead: ♣J

Win the ♣Q and play a small ♥ to dummy's ♥J, which holds the trick.

I hope you didn't continue drawing trumps by playing the ♥K. If you did then you are going down in an ice-cold contract.

The way to lose only one ♥ trick is to keep leading toward dummy's honors. So come to your hand with a black card and play another ♥ in that direction, leading through East's ♥A. When you win that trick repeat the maneuver.

It is really against the odds for East to hold ♥ A 10 9 x. In fact it would only occur perhaps one time in seven.

But there is no reason to go down once every seven times when you don't need to.

Partner's 2♦ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♥.

Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner tells you that he has enough points to be in game, and that he holds exactly 5 ♥s. With your 3 ♥s you know of an 8-card Major fit so you correct the contract to 4♥.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♣J. You win the opening lead with your ♣Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = ?

The 2 ♦ losers are unavoidable, and even you will have to give up a trick to the Ace of trumps. So you have to make sure not to lose a second ♥.

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A K J 5
 ♥ A J 10 5
 ♦ A 6 4
 ♣ 8 3

♠ 10 9 2

♥ Q 7 3

♦ 9 8 7

♣ K 9 6 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q 4

♥ K 8 6 2

♦ K Q J 3

♣ A 7 5

♠ 8 7 6 3

♥ 9 4

♦ 10 5 2

♣ Q J 10 4

West	North	East	South
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♥	Pass
6♥			
All Pass			
6♥ by East			
Lead: ♣Q			

The 2♣ bid was Stayman, so you bid your ♥s.

Partner takes the direct approach and puts you in slam.

East plays 6♥. South leads the ♣Q. South finds their best lead, exposing your ♣ loser right off the bat.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

If you can guess the ♥ finesse correctly you will make 7, discarding dummy's ♣ loser on the fourth ♦. But if you guess wrong they will immediately set you with a ♣ trick.

There is a better way - one that combines two chances. Win the ♣A. Then play your ♥A and ♥K. If the ♥Q happens to fall, pull the last trump and run your winners.

If the ♥Q **DOESN'T** fall, (she won't of course), switch to ♦s. On the fourth round of ♦s discard dummy's ♣, whether it is ruffed with the ♥Q or not.

If you knew to play the North for the ♥Q then you wouldn't need this improved plan.

But playing the deal as described will win whenever the ♥Q is doubleton, **OR** when the player with the protected ♥Q holds at least 3 ♦s.

Pretty good odds, better than the going rate for finesses, which is 50% off.

There was an alternate plan, just as good. After taking the two top trumps, run the ♠s, discarding two ♣s from your hand. As you see, either would have worked.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10 8 5 3

♥ K 5

♦ 8 7 4 3

♣ 9 3

♠ 6 2

♥ A 10 9

♦ 10 6 5

♣ K Q 7 6 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 9 7

♥ 8 7 6 4 2

♦ A 9

♣ 10 8 2

♠ Q J 4

♥ Q J 3

♦ K Q J 2

♣ A J 5

West

North

East

South

Pass

2NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by South

Lead: ♠ 5

started with a 5-card suit. That means East still has a ♠. The instant you play a ♦ one of the defenders will grab the ♦ A and West will take his three more ♠ tricks.

As much as you hate to put your contract in the hands of a 50% finesse chance, that is what you must do. Forget the ♦ suit and finesse West for the ♥ K, trying for two extra tricks in ♥ s.

West played very well to duck the second ♠, leaving his partner with a ♠ in case he could get the lead.

So you have to play well and stay away from ♦ s.

Partner's 2NT bid invites you to bid game if you have a maximum hand. You aren't thrilled by all the Quacks in your hand but with 17 points you bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠ 5. East wins the first trick with the ♠ K and returns the ♠ 9. West plays the ♠ 3 under your ♠ J.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 5 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more tricks, and the ♦ suit will provide them after you drive out the ♦ A.

Is that what you should do?

That is definitely **NOT** what you should do. West led the ♠ 5, then played the ♠ 3 to the second trick. You have seen the ♠ 4 and ♠ 2 so it is clear that West

Board 4

East Deals

Both Vul

♠ 7

♥ K Q J 9 8 7 5

♦ A

♣ A 8 4 2

♠ Q J 10 6

♥ 6

♦ K 8 5 4 2

♣ Q 9 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K 5 4

♥ A 3 2

♦ Q J 10

♣ J 7 6

♠ 9 8 3 2

♥ 10 4

♦ 9 7 6 3

♣ K 10 5

West

North

East

South

4♣

Pass

4♠

Pass

6♥

All Pass

6♥ by West

Lead: ♠Q

3

There would be nothing wrong with a transfer bid here, but probably no advantage either. What you really want to know is how many Aces partner has. So you ask him with a Gerber 4♣ bid.

Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

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Partner says 4♠ (2 Aces),

Looking at three possible ♣ losers you bid 6♥.

West plays 6♥. North leads the ♠Q. The first trick is easy; you win with dummy's ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total =

It can't do any good to ruff your fourth ♣ in dummy because you would have to lose two before that could happen. Of course one of your ♣s can be discarded on dummy's ♠K but what about the other two?

Suppose you win the ♠ and unblock the ♦A. Play ♥K, then to dummy's ♥A. Take one ♣ discard on the ♠K, then play the ♦Q and discard a second ♣.

It won't work. You would establish the ♦ for your last discard but you have no entry to it.

This will work. At trick 2 discard the ♦A on dummy's ♠K. Play the ♦Q and discard a ♣ when South doesn't cover. North will take the ♦K and attack ♣s but you are in control now. You win your ♣A, pull trumps, ending in dummy, and discard the remaining 2 ♣ losers on dummy's ♦J 10.

This is called a Jettison play. You sacrifice your ♦A to unblock the suit for dummy's ♦Q J 10.

If South held the ♦K the play would be slightly different; you would have to ruff when he covered. But the result would be the same.

Did you notice that you started with 3 ♣ losers and no ♦ loser, but you ended up losing 1 ♦ and no ♣s?

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 7 6 5

♥ J 10 6 2

♦ 8

♣ A 8 4 2

♠ A K 9 2

♥ A 8 7 4

♦ K 4 2

♣ J 10



♠ Q J

♥ K Q 3

♦ Q J 10 9 6 5

♣ 7 6

♠ 8 4 3

♥ 9 5

♦ A 7 3

♣ K Q 9 5 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

2♦

2NT

Pass

3♣

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♦Q

First decide about what to do at trick #1. If you hold up and East plays another ♦, no harm will be done. But probably no good will be done either because East is likely to have 6 ♦s, leaving West with just a singleton anyway. But what if East pockets the one ♦ trick and switches to ♥s, a suit where you only have one stopper? Since that might turn out badly, you should **NOT** hold up.

As to which hand to win it in, that's easy. You need to preserve any dummy entries that you can so you win the first trick with your ♦K.

Now you establish some ♣ winners. You play the ♣J and both defenders play low.

You have to assume that defenders good enough to hold up their ♣A at the first opportunity will be good enough to do it on the second play also. But you can thwart them by next playing your ♣10 and overtaking with dummy's ♣Q. Even if they do hold up again you can continue with another ♣ from dummy to establish the suit while you still have the ♦A for an entry.

If you fail to overtake the second ♣ West will hold up the ♣A again.

Then you will lose all those ♣ tricks in dummy.

Partner's 2NT is the lebensohl convention. He requests that you bid 3♣ as a relay, which you do. Partner now bids 3NT.

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When partner bids 3NT AFTER the lebensohl 2NT, he is suggesting you play there, and he guarantees a stopper in their suit. You are happy to pass.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♦Q. East attacks in ♦s and you must make an immediate choice. Hold up, win in dummy, or win in your hand.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 5